

Preparing for an attack

Meanwhile, North Vietnam built up its strength. With no American bombers to threaten its security, the Ho Chi Minh Trail became a paved highway with an oil pipeline. As men and munitions flowed into South Vietnam, the North made significant gains in 1974, especially around Da Nang, in coastal Quang Ngai province, and north of Saigon. In spite of these gains, the North Vietnamese politburo remained cautious—while they planned a major offensive for 1975, they did not expect victory until 1976.



Rifle with grenade launcher

The M16A1, here fitted with an M203 grenade launcher, became the US military's standard assault rifle during the Vietnam War. The Americans left the South Vietnamese army well equipped with such state-of-the-art weaponry.

“Certain war has **yielded** to an **uncertain peace** in Vietnam.”

HENRY KISSINGER, NOBEL PEACE PRIZE ACCEPTANCE SPEECH, DECEMBER 1973